how this 'naya Pakistan' is in line with the existing security state. Khan has been accused by his opponents of being the 'chosen one' of the security establishment, with his victory attributed to a rigged election. The events leading up to the 2018 elections testify to a biased position against the PML(N) and the PPP evident in the actions of the security state that attempted to derail the electoral campaigns of the two main political parties.

The EU Election Observation Mission (EOM) highlights the restrictive environment before the 2018 elections including the manner by which the previously elected prime minister Nawaz Sharif was disqualified on charges of corruption 'that reshaped the political environment ahead of the elections' (2018, p. 10). Sharif was implicated in what came to be known as the 'Panamagate scandal' after the release of the Panama papers[2] that revealed links between the Sharif family and undeclared offshore accounts. The dismissal of Nawaz Sharif by the judiciary led to allegations of the security state's influence over the judicial proceedings especially in the manner in which Sharif was disqualified for life in April 2018, and sentenced to ten years in prison in July, just a few weeks before the elections (Shah 2019; Barker 2018; also see Afzal 2018a). Selective censorship of the media was also problematic. According to EU EOM (2018) media outlets had been contacted by 'state actors' (read: 'khalai makhlooq'[3]) instructing them not to show Nawaz Sharif's return to Pakistan from England for his arrest; nor were they allowed to show interviews with the Sharif family prior to their departure from England. PTI's political rhetoric was in line with the security state, in challenging the position of Nawaz Sharif and the PML(N), given Imran Khan's mandate was anti-corruption. Ironically, despite these accusations of corruption against politicians from other political parties, PTI welcomed many defectors who had previously been on the receiving end of PTI's anti-corruption drive, as they were considered 'electables' (Shah 2019). Yet, prior to the 2018 elections, PML(N) and its workers faced the worst kind of state censorship. Other political parties such as the PPP often faced delays and at times outright denial of licences to hold rallies, a problem that PTI hardly ever encountered (Afzal 2018b).

The problem of election rigging became apparent on election day. The Election Commission of Pakistan had given 'judicial powers to military personnel' who were deployed inside polling stations to ensure 'free and fair elections'. However, there were cases of polling agents being expelled from the polling stations, evident also in 'an audit' by NGOs that found that 'the official document for tabulating results at each polling station… was in 95 percent of cases lacking the polling agent's signature required by law' (Shah 2019, p. 137). Despite the interference by the security state, there were also examples of individuals being elected who